

He therefore ordered a huge attack for June 2, but not all the Union troops were in place, so he reluctantly postponed to the following morning.

That night Lee's engineers strengthened their lines, shoring up weak spots and designing a broad zigzag pattern that created converging fields of fire, staked out with measured distances so that the artillery could better estimate range. The art of field fortification that the Confederates had been working on since Spotsylvania was now perfected in the flat fields around Cold Harbor. Though there was a steady patter of falling rain, the ominous noise of the Confederate soldiers strengthening their breastworks carried hundreds of yards to the ears of waiting Union soldiers. Grim premonitions swept through the ranks; many men pinned their names to their tunics so that burial parties would be better able to identify them.

6,500

The estimated number of Union soldiers who fell within the first hour of the charge at Cold Harbor on June 3, 1864—over one-quarter of the 25,000 men sent to attack the Confederate fieldworks that morning.